

Ethics in Real Life

Analyzing Hard Problems Through Multiple Ethical Lenses

Social, Ethical & Legal Issues | HCMUS-FITUS



1. The Kant & Utilitarian Audits

```
def KantAudit(action):  
    rule = "What if everyone did this?"  
    respect = "Am I using someone only as a tool?"  
    motive = "Am I doing the right thing for the right reason?"  
  
    if fails(rule) or fails(respect):  
        return "Not Kant-approved"  
    return "Morally safer"  
  
def UtilitarianAudit(action):  
    net_happiness = calculate_benefits(action) - calculate_harms(action)  
    return "Acceptable" if net_happiness > 0 else "Wrong"
```

2.The Society & Character Audits

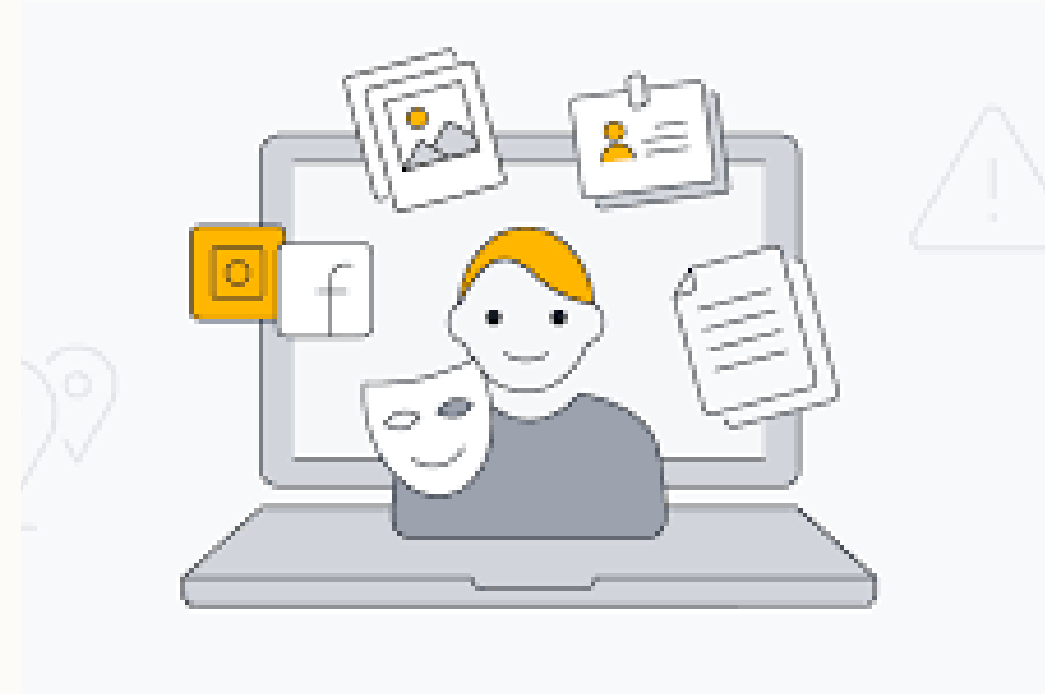
```
def ContractAudit(action):  
    implicit_rule = get_system_agreement(action)  
    if unilaterally_breaches(implicit_rule):  
        return "System Collapse Risk"  
    return "Contract Honored"  
  
def CultureAudit(action):  
    local_norm = fetch_cultural_context(location="VN")  
    return "Tension" if conflicts_with(local_norm) else "Culturally Acceptable"  
  
def VirtueAudit(action):  
    return is_honest(action) and builds_good_character(action)
```

Today's Cases

1. **Vietnamese Social Media:** Doxxing & Online Reputation Attacks
2. **Computer Science:** AI Training Data Scraped Without Consent
3. **University Life:** The Class Monitor's Attendance Favour

Case 1: Doxxing & Reputation Attacks

- **Scenario:** A student is falsely accused of cheating. Their ID, phone, and name are posted online.
- **The Spread:** Goes viral overnight. Classmates and strangers share it. Victim receives hate.
- **Question:** When sharing unverified content harms someone, who is morally responsible?

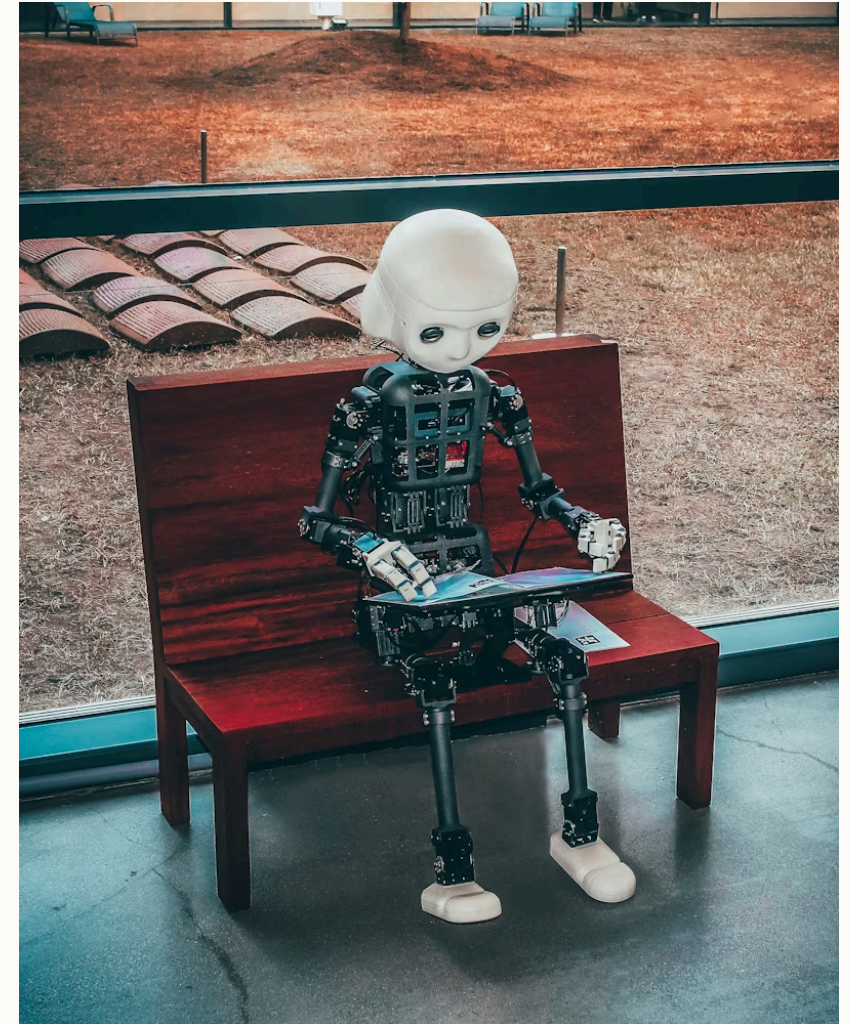


Case 1: Ethical Analysis

-  **Kantianism (FAIL):** Treating victims as clickbait, not humans. Fails universal trust.
-  **Act Utilitarianism (WRONG):** Harm (trauma) vastly outweighs viral entertainment.
-  **Cultural Relativism (TENSION):** Shaming is culturally normalized, but real harm remains.
-  **Social Contract (FAIL):** Breaks implicit rule: don't weaponize private data.
-  **Virtue Ethics (WRONG):** Lacks honesty and fairness.
-  **Verdict:** Spreading unverified doxxing content is universally morally wrong.

Case 2: AI Training Data Scraped

- **Scenario:** AI company scrapes billions of artworks/writings from the web without consent.
- **The Conflict:** AI competes with creators. Company claims "fair use".
- **Question:** Is scraping public work without consent ethically justified just because it's legal?



Case 2: Ethical Analysis

-  **Kantianism (FAIL):** Uses creators merely as data sources.
-  **Act Utilitarianism (SPLIT):** Massive user benefit vs. long-term harm to creative industry.
-  **Cultural Relativism (CONTESTED):** Western 'fair use' differs from cultures stressing authorship.
-  **Social Contract (FAIL):** Breaks implicit trust of publishing work.
-  **Virtue Ethics (WRONG):** Lacks honesty (no disclosure) and fairness (no pay).
-  **Verdict:** Technical legality $\neq$ moral justification. Ethical AI requires consent.

Case 3: Attendance Favour

- **Scenario:** 20 out of 40 students skip PE class. The absent students ask the monitor to mark them present.
- **The Context:** The lecturer is lenient. The core goal is simply to get IT students exercising.
- **Question:** Is falsifying attendance acceptable if the students are otherwise resting or doing their own workouts?



Case 3: Ethical Analysis

-  **Act Utilitarianism (ACCEPTABLE):** The core goal (health) is met. Resting or self-exercising maximizes well-being for exhausted IT students without causing direct harm.
-  **Cultural Relativism (TENSION):** 'Tình bạn' (friendship) justifies the favor, though lying to authority remains a mild taboo.
-  **Kantianism (FAIL):** Intentions and physical health don't excuse the act of lying.
-  **Social Contract (FAIL):** Still a unilateral breach of the institutional "show up, get credit" rule.
-  **Virtue Ethics (WRONG):** A virtuous person does not use deception to achieve a healthy outcome.

Theory Comparison

Theory	Doxxing	AI Scraping	Attendance
 Kantianism	✗ Wrong	✗ Wrong	✗ Wrong
 Social Contract	✗ Wrong	✗ Wrong	✗ Wrong
 Virtue Ethics	✗ Wrong	✗ Wrong	✗ Wrong
 Cultural Relativism	⚠ Tension	⚠ Contested	⚠ Tension
 Act Utilitarianism	✗ Wrong	⚠ Split	✓ Acceptable

Three Key Takeaways

1. **Good intentions $\neq$ ethical actions:** Intent alone doesn't satisfy strict ethical frameworks like Kantianism.
2. **Context can shift the math:** Utilitarianism allows flexibility if the ultimate goal (e.g., student health/rest) is achieved without collateral harm.
3. **Multiple lenses sharpen judgment:** When frameworks disagree, it reveals exactly where our values are in conflict and sparks the best debates.

THANK YOU FOR LISTENING !!!